MODULE 26 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Exam Mechanics and Strategy

What HashiCorp publishes, what it does not, and how to spend sixty minutes.

COVERS The exam itself PRODUCT CONTENT None MODULE 26 of 27

admin@sthithapragna.com

Sixty minutes, one attempt, no free retake. **Pace is part of the exam**, not something that happens around it.

What HashiCorp publishes

FACT	VALUE
Exam name	HashiCorp Certified: Terraform Associate (004)
Terraform version tested	1.12
Duration	60 minutes
Format	Online proctored, delivered via Certiverse
Question types	Multiple choice, multiple answer, and true/false
Fee, language, validity	$70.50 plus local taxes. English only. Valid 2 years

ON THE EXAM

No free retake is included. A second attempt costs the full fee again, which is worth knowing before you book.

What HashiCorp does not publish

- **The number of questions.** Widely quoted figures of 57 or 60 do not come from HashiCorp.
- **The passing score.** Estimates of around seventy per cent are third-party guesses.
- **Domain weights.** This course's percentages are derived, and are stated as such.
- So do not build a strategy on a target score, because nobody outside HashiCorp knows what it is.
- **You do get an immediate pass or fail**, and an objective-level report shortly afterwards.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Any source quoting a precise question count or pass mark is quoting somebody's estimate. Treat it as such.

The three question types

- **Multiple choice.** One correct answer from several. The most common form.
- **Multiple answer.** Two or three correct, and the question tells you how many.
- **True or false.** A single statement to judge.
- **The question bank behind this course is about one fifth true/false**, which is a fair guide to expect.
- There are **no labs, no code editors and no free text.** Everything is a selection.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Nothing here requires you to write Terraform. It requires you to read it, and to judge statements about it.

Multiple answer questions

- **The question states how many to choose.** Read that number before reading the options.
- **Selecting the wrong count is a wasted question**, however good your reasoning was.
- Treat each option as its own true-or-false question, then count the trues.
- If you get more trues than the question wants, **one of them is subtly wrong**. Find it.
- If you get fewer, you have **ruled something out too quickly**. Reconsider your weakest rejection.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Choose two means exactly two. The count is a constraint you can use, not just an instruction to follow.

True or false questions

- **The whole statement must be true.** One wrong clause makes the whole thing false.
- Read compound statements clause by clause, and stop at the first one that fails.
- Watch absolute words: **always, never, all, only, must, cannot**. They are often where a true statement breaks.
- **But absolutes are not automatically false.** Plenty of Terraform rules genuinely are absolute.
- Example: state **always** holds attribute values in plain text. True, and absolute.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The old test-taking advice that absolutes are usually false does not hold here. Judge the claim, not the wording.

Reading a scenario question

- **Find the requirement first.** It is usually the last sentence, and it is what the options are judged against.
- **Planted details are constraints.** 'Must not cause downtime', 'no credentials available', 'nine workspaces'.
- **Several options often work.** The question asks which fits the stated requirement, not which is possible.
- **Eliminate rather than select.** Rejecting three options is usually easier than justifying one.
- If two survive elimination, **re-read the requirement**. One of them fails a detail you skimmed.

> ON THE EXAM
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> This course's scenarios were written the same way. Every one has a sentence that eliminates an otherwise correct option.

Spending the hour

- **An hour is not long.** Whatever the question count, that is roughly a minute each.
- **Answer every question as you reach it**, even if you flag it. Never leave a blank behind you.
- **An unanswered question cannot earn a mark. A guess can.** Leaving one blank is a certain zero.
- **Flag and move on after about ninety seconds.** The next question may be one you know instantly.
- **Reserve the last five minutes** for flagged questions and for checking every item has an answer.

> ON THE EXAM
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> HashiCorp does not publish scoring detail, and no scheme rewards a blank more than a guess. Answer everything.

The proctored setup

- **Delivered remotely via Certiverse**, with a live proctor, system checks and a room scan.
- **A valid government ID is required**, and the name must match your certification profile.
- **Run the system check days beforehand**, not on the day. Camera, microphone, browser, network.
- **Clear the desk**, and expect to show the room. No notes, no second screen, no phone.
- Accessibility accommodations are available, and need **requesting in advance**.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Most preventable failures on the day are logistical: a mismatched name, an untested camera, a cluttered desk.

Afterwards, and staying certified

- **You get an immediate pass or fail**, with an objective-level report following shortly.
- **That report is worth reading even if you passed**, because it shows where your weakest domain was.
- **The credential is valid for two years.**
- Renew by **retaking the Associate exam**, from six months before expiry, or by passing the Professional exam.
- **There is no discounted renewal at Associate level.** A retake is the full fee.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Passing the higher Terraform exam extends the Associate credential, which is worth knowing if you plan to continue.

The strategy, in one table

SITUATION	WHAT TO DO
A scenario question	Read the last sentence first, then eliminate
Two options both look right	Re-read the requirement. One fails a detail
A multiple answer question	Read the count, judge each option separately, then count
A true/false compound statement	Clause by clause. Stop at the first failure
Ninety seconds gone, still unsure	Answer it anyway, flag it, move on
Five minutes left	Revisit flags, and confirm nothing is unanswered

ON THE EXAM

None of this is about knowing more Terraform. It is about converting what you already know into marks.

> A question describes a team needing to stop Terraform managing a resource while keeping the object. Two options both achieve that: a removed block with destroy set to false, and terraform state rm.
>
> The last sentence of the scenario says the change must be reviewed in a pull request.

How should a candidate proceed?

A Pick either. Both achieve the stated outcome

B Re-read the requirement. Only one of the two is reviewable in a pull request

C Pick the older mechanism, since exams usually test fundamentals

D Flag it and guess later, since two options are technically correct

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should a candidate proceed?

A **Pick either**

Both achieve the outcome, and only one satisfies the requirement. That gap is what the last sentence exists to create.

B **Re-read the requirement**

Correct. A removed block appears in a plan and lives in configuration; state rm runs from a terminal with no review. The requirement decides it.

C **Prefer the older mechanism**

A guessing heuristic, not reasoning. It also happens to be wrong here, since the newer mechanism is the reviewable one.

D **Flag and guess**

Reasonable when genuinely stuck, and premature here. The deciding information is in the question and takes seconds to use.

THE SIGNAL

When two options both work, the requirement sentence is doing the work. This is how nearly every scenario in this course was built.

> A true or false question reads: marking a variable as sensitive prevents its value from being written to the state file, and suppresses it in plan output.
>
> A candidate knows the second half is true and is unsure about the first.

What is the answer, and why?

A. True. The second clause is correct, and the first is the intended meaning of sensitive

B. False. The whole statement must be true, and sensitive does not affect state

C. True, provided the backend is encrypted

D. Cannot be determined without knowing the Terraform version

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the answer, and why?

A — True, second clause correct

A compound statement is true only if every clause is true. One correct half does not rescue an incorrect one.

B — False, on the first clause

Correct. sensitive controls display and never storage, so the first clause fails and the whole statement is false.

C — True if encrypted

Encryption protects the file at rest. The value is still written, and anyone with read access sees it.

D — Version-dependent

This has been true throughout. It is not a behaviour that changed between releases.

THE SIGNAL

This is the course's most-repeated misconception, dressed as a compound statement. Half-true reads as true unless you check each clause.

> A candidate has twelve minutes left and eleven questions remaining. Four of the remaining questions are long scenarios. They have three earlier questions flagged for review.
>
> They are considering going back to the flagged ones first, since they have already read them.

What is the better plan?

A Revisit the three flagged questions first, since they are partly understood

B Work forward through the eleven unseen questions, then return to flags with whatever remains

C Answer the seven short questions, skip the four scenarios, then revisit flags

D Slow down and answer carefully, accepting that some will go unanswered

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the better plan?

A. Flags first

Spends scarce time on questions that already have answers, while eleven questions have none. Familiarity is not the same as value.

B. Unseen first, flags after

Correct. An unseen question is worth a mark you do not have; a flagged one already has an answer that may well be right.

C. Skip the scenarios

Skipping guarantees zero on four questions. Even a rushed read of a scenario beats not reading it.

D. Slow down

Accepts unanswered questions as a cost of care. With eleven left and twelve minutes, that trade loses more than it gains.

THE SIGNAL

A flagged question already has an answer. An unseen one has nothing. Under time pressure, unseen questions are worth more.

> A question asks which two statements about the dependency lock file are correct, and offers five options. A candidate is confident about three of them.
>
> They consider selecting all three, reasoning that partial credit is likely.

What should they do?

A. Select all three. Partial credit is standard on multiple answer questions

B. Select exactly two. One of their three is subtly wrong, and finding it is the question

C. Select one, to avoid the risk of a wrong selection

D. Leave it blank and return to it, since three seem correct

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should they do?

A Select all three

The question asks for two. Selecting three is not a partially correct answer to that question; it is an invalid one.

B Select exactly two

Correct. The count is a constraint, and having one option too many means one of them fails on a detail. Finding it is the question.

C Select one

Also the wrong count, and it discards a selection they were confident about to avoid a risk that does not exist.

D Leave it blank

A blank is a certain zero. Two of the three, chosen on the best available reasoning, is strictly better.

THE SIGNAL

Having one option too many is information. It tells you exactly where to look, because one of your three has a flaw.

Module 26 recap

- **60 minutes, online proctored, $70.50 plus tax, valid two years, no free retake.**
- **HashiCorp publishes no question count, no passing score and no domain weights.**
- **Read the requirement first, then eliminate.** Two workable options means a detail decides it.
- **A compound true/false statement is false if any clause fails.**
- **Answer everything as you reach it.** A blank is a certain zero; a guess is not.
- **Run the system check days ahead**, and match your ID to your profile name.

> ON THE EXAM
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> None of this adds knowledge. All of it converts knowledge you already have into marks you might otherwise lose.